

and untouched. Once you've convinced yourself that it's the best possible flavour of Linux for your use, you can go ahead and install a permanent copy of the Operating System onto your disk, either alongside your existing OS (called a dual-boot scenario) or replacing your current OS. Either way, the steps remain the same, and in the end you should have a fresh Linux distro ready to fiddle around with.

If you've installed Linux before, don't worry, the steps remain largely the same. If you remember from the last time you went shopping for the 'right' distribution, you'll remember that you had to make a lot of choices, particularly regarding the nature of the graphical interface you'd be using. The task of drawing the windows, toolbars, mouse pointer and other interface elements you interact with is given to a program called a Window Manager. There are mainly two types of Window Managers - Tiling WMs and Floating WMs. Tiling Window Managers don't allow application windows to overlap, but continually split the available space into smaller and smaller portions, allowing you to view them all at once. These are typically lighter in terms of system resources used, and are tailored for keyboard-based navigation. Floating WMs are more familiar to Windows/OS X users (since the default WM on these systems is a floating one) and allow you to freely resize, minimize and maximize windows. These might be more memory intensive, but are considered easier to use and require almost no configuration, besides being more familiar to most.

A Desktop Environment is a combination of a Window Manager along with some pre-configured defaults, a brief selection of applications and some UI elements like desktop icons, widgets and wallpapers. While there are thousands of Linux distributions out there to choose from, a lot of them are just a combinations of package managers (the tool you use to install/remove software) and desktop environments. We'll help you pick out a Desktop Environment based on your use case, and leave the other half to you - package managers are largely a personal preference.

I. Installation

Installing Linux on any modern computer is really easy, but it's easy to get overwhelmed by the choices available. There's an almost intimidating level of choice when it comes to Linux distributions and the desktop environments they ship with - why, sometimes the same distribution will have several different flavours or 'spins' (We're looking at you, Ubuntu), but if you're new to the whole process, we suggest you stick with Ubuntu.